



Don't Die Retired

6-WEEK PLAN

Reconnect

Six weeks to a fuller social life after 50



Printable • Written for everyone over 50

Whether you've always been active or never got round to it

dontdieretired.com

WELCOME

Reconnect

Six weeks to a fuller social life after 50. Retirement is a word for leaving a job, not a description of a person — and this 6-week plan is written for anyone over 50 who wants to do more, not less, whether you've always been active or never got round to it.

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Print it

It's made for paper. Pin the tracker pages somewhere you'll see them every day.

Start small

Every plan has a beginner's route. Doing a little, often, beats doing a lot once.

Tick the box

A row of ticks is surprisingly powerful. It's how a habit becomes part of your life.

This guide is general information about social wellbeing, not medical advice. Feeling lonely is not an illness, but low mood that lasts more than a couple of weeks, or that stops you doing everyday things, is worth talking about. If that is where you are, please speak to your GP (family doctor).
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Six weeks to a fuller social life after 50. Not a personality transplant. Not a networking course. A calm, practical plan for rebuilding friendships, community and family connection when your circle has got smaller than you would like.

Circles shrink. It happens quietly and for perfectly ordinary reasons: you retire and the daily company of colleagues stops; a partner or close friend dies; you move house to be nearer family or further from the noise; the children leave, and the school-gate and sports-club acquaintances leave with them; or you become a carer and the weeks fill up with appointments instead of people. None of it is a failing. All of it is fixable, at least in part, and more easily than you might think.

Reconnect is built on one idea: **connection is a practice, not a personality trait**. Some people find it easier than others, but everyone gets better with small, regular, deliberate steps. Six weeks of them — about twenty minutes on most days, plus one or two slightly bigger tasks each week — is enough to change the shape of your week. Not into a whirl of parties. Into a week with more people in it who are glad to see you.



How to use this guide

Read Parts 1 to 8 in one or two sittings (about an hour in all).

Do the seven-day audit in Part 2 before you start Week 1. It is the foundation of everything else.

Print the progress log at the back, or copy it into a notebook.

Then follow the six-week plan one week at a time. Adapt the days freely; keep the rhythm.

01 Part 1: Why connection matters

The first thing to say is that if you are lonelier than you would like, you are in very large company. The World Health Organization's Commission on Social Connection reported in 2025 that about one in six people worldwide is affected by loneliness, and that up to one in three older adults is estimated to be socially isolated. In the United States, AARP's 2025 research found that 40 per cent of adults aged 45 and over report feeling lonely, up from 35 per cent in both 2010 and 2018. In Great Britain, the Campaign to End Loneliness reports that around 7 per cent of people — close to four million — experience chronic loneliness, meaning they feel lonely often or always.

Those are not figures about odd or unlikeable people. They are figures about ordinary people whose lives changed shape. The AARP research names the triggers plainly: retirement, adult children moving away, and bereavement. If one of those is your story, your loneliness is a predictable response to a real loss, not evidence that something is wrong with you.

■ What the evidence says

- **Loneliness and isolation affect physical health, not just mood.** The WHO Commission links them to a higher risk of stroke, heart disease, diabetes and cognitive decline, and to roughly 871,000 deaths a year worldwide — about 100 every hour. The Campaign to End Loneliness cites research suggesting loneliness can raise the risk of early death by around a quarter.
- **The mental-health link is strong.** The WHO reports that loneliness roughly doubles the likelihood of depression. The Campaign to End Loneliness reports that 60 per cent of people who are chronically lonely experience mental distress, against 15 per cent of those who are not.
- **Participation is what has fallen.** AARP's research finds that lonely adults over 45 in the US spend about 7.3 hours a day alone, against 5.6 hours for those who are not lonely, and that declining involvement in religious services, volunteering and local groups goes with the rise in disconnection.
- **Screens are not a substitute.** The same AARP research notes that technology helps maintain existing relationships, but that solitary online activity rarely creates new, meaningful ones. Use the phone to reach people; do not let it stand in for them.
- **Doing something works.** Age UK, the Campaign to End Loneliness and the NHS all point to the same practical routes: regular contact, group activity, volunteering and befriending. None of them is glamorous. All of them are available to you this week.

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In this Report, we pull back the curtain on loneliness and isolation as a defining challenge of our time.

Dr Vivek Murthy, co-chair of the WHO Commission on Social Connection, WHO news release, 30 June 2025



The plain summary

Loneliness after 50 is common and usually follows a real change in your life.

It matters for your body as well as your mood.

The cure is not a big personality; it is more regular contact, more shared activity and more giving.

All three are learnable. That is what the next six weeks are for.

Lonely is not the same as alone. Being alone is a fact: nobody else is in the room. Being lonely is a feeling: the gap between the connection you have and the connection you want. Plenty of people live alone and are not lonely; plenty live in full houses and are. This guide is about the feeling, not the headcount. If you love your own company and simply want two or three more good friends, that is a perfectly good goal. If you want a busy diary, that is a good goal too. Decide which you are before Week 1, because they need slightly different plans.

■ Why circles shrink after 50

It helps to know the mechanism, because then you can reverse it. Most adult friendships are held together by **repeated, low-effort, unplanned contact**: the corridor at work, the school gate, the touchline, the neighbour you passed every morning. When the setting goes — retirement, a move, the children leaving — the friendships often go with it, not because anyone chose to end them but because nobody had to choose to keep them. Nothing was wrong with the friendships. They just lost their scaffolding.

Rebuilding, then, is mostly about **rebuilding scaffolding**: putting yourself back in places where the same people see you regularly, and adding a little deliberate effort where the unplanned contact used to be. That is the whole method. The rest of this guide is detail.

02 Part 2: An honest audit of this week

Before changing anything, measure it. For seven days, keep a simple log of every real contact you have with another person — a conversation, not a transaction. The postman saying 'morning' counts if you talked; paying at the till without a word does not. Be honest rather than flattering. Nobody will see this but you.

Day	Who I spoke with	How (in person / phone / video / message)	Roughly how long	How it left me feeling
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

At the end of the week, sit down with the log and a cup of something and answer these five questions in writing.

- 1 How many different people did I actually talk with?** Not messages exchanged; conversations. Many people are surprised by how small the number is — and equally surprised by how small a change makes a difference.
- 2 How many contacts were in person?** Phone and video are good. In person is better for the feeling of being connected. If almost everything was through a screen, that is the first thing to shift.
- 3 Who did I want to hear from and didn't?** Write their names. This is your re-contact list for Part 4.
- 4 Which contact left me feeling best?** Notice what it had in common: a shared activity, a laugh, being useful, being listened to. That is the ingredient to look for more of.
- 5 Where were the empty days?** Empty days are not a fault; they are a gap in the scaffolding. The plan will put something regular into at least two of them.

■ The three circles

It is useful to sort the people in your life into three rough circles. Most people over 50 find their inner circle has held up, their outer circle has vanished, and the middle is where the loss actually happened. The plan works on all three, but the middle circle gets the most attention, because it is where most day-to-day company comes from.

Circle	Who belongs here	Write the names
Inner	The two to five people you could ring at 2 a.m. Partner, closest friends, perhaps a sibling or an adult child.	
Middle	People you enjoy and see or speak to regularly, but would not ring in a crisis. Old colleagues, walking companions, neighbours you have dinner with, the friend from choir.	
Outer	People you know by name and exchange a few words with. The dog-walkers, the librarian, the people at the class, the neighbour two doors down.	



A note on grief

If your circle shrank because someone died, the audit may be painful, because the empty space in it has a name. That is all right. You are not replacing anyone. You are looking after the person they would have wanted looked after. Go at whatever pace you can manage, and if any of the weeks below feel too much, do half of them.

03 Part 3: The weak-ties idea

In the 1970s the sociologist Mark Granovetter published a paper called 'The Strength of Weak Ties'. Its argument, much borrowed since, was that the acquaintances at the edge of your life — the people you know slightly — are not a poor substitute for close friends. They do a different job. They connect you to news, opportunities and other people that your close friends, who mostly know the same things you do, cannot. Your best friend's world overlaps with yours; your outer circle's world reaches out into places you have never been.

For anyone rebuilding a social life, this is enormously encouraging, because **weak ties are the easiest ties to make**. Nobody has to like you deeply. Nobody has to make time for you. All that is needed is to be somewhere regularly, to be pleasant, and to say slightly more than the minimum. And weak ties are where middle-circle friendships come from: every close friend you have ever had was once someone you knew slightly.

- Knowing the name of the person who serves you coffee, and them knowing yours.
- The other regulars at a class, a swim session, a parkrun or a church service, whom you nod to and then, after a few weeks, chat to.
- The neighbour you talk to over the bins about the weather, the council and the state of the road.
- The volunteer you share a shift with, whose life you gradually learn about in ten-minute instalments.
- The person at the library, the allotment (community garden), the Men's Shed, the bowls club, who always seems to be there on Thursdays.

■ How to grow weak ties on purpose

- 1 **Be a regular.** Same place, same day, same time. Recognition is the whole game, and it only comes from repetition. Pick two things this week — a café, a class, a walk, a service — and go at the same time each week for six weeks.
- 2 **Say one more sentence than usual.** 'Morning' becomes 'Morning — busier than usual today.' A question about the other person's week beats any comment about the weather. You are not being intrusive; you are being noticeably friendly, which almost everyone likes.
- 3 **Learn and use names.** Ask early ('I'm Chris, by the way — I don't think I've asked your name'). Write new names down when you get home. Using someone's name the second time you meet them is the cheapest good impression there is.
- 4 **Offer small help.** Hold the door, pass on the article, lend the book, save the seat. Being slightly useful is how acquaintances become people who like you.
- 5 **Let it take time.** A weak tie takes a few weeks of repetition to become a nod, and a few more to become a chat. Do not force it into friendship. Most weak ties stay weak ties, and that is fine; a handful, over a year, will become something more.



The rule of three

Nothing counts until you have been three times. The first visit to anything is awkward for everyone, including the people who have been going for years. The second is better. By the third, someone will say 'oh, you're back'. Decide in advance that you will go three times before judging.

04 Part 4: Reaching back to old friends

Almost everyone over 50 has people they were once close to and simply lost track of. The friendship did not end; it lapsed. A house move, a busy decade, an illness, a change of job, and suddenly it has been eight years and getting in touch feels strange. It is not strange. It is one of the most reliably welcome things you can do.

People consistently underestimate how pleased others are to hear from them. When you imagine sending the message, you picture the other person's surprise and mild irritation. In reality, they mostly picture the same thing about you — which is why neither of you has written. The person who breaks the silence is almost never the one who ends up embarrassed. The worst realistic outcome is a warm reply and nothing more. The best is a friendship back.

Two things make it easier. First, keep it short and expectation-free: you are saying hello, not proposing a reunion tour. Second, give one concrete reason for writing today: something reminded you of them, you found a photograph, you passed the old office. A reason takes the weight off both of you.

These are hypothetical templates, not real messages from real people. Change every word that does not sound like you. The shape is what matters: a reason, a memory, a light question, and no pressure.

i Script 1 — the simple hello (text, email or card)

Hello [name] — I was clearing out a drawer and found the photo from [the walking weekend / the office Christmas do / the year we did the allotment]. It made me laugh, and I realised it has been far too long. How are you? No need for a long reply — I'd just love to know how life is treating you. [Your name]

i Script 2 — after a bereavement or big change (theirs or yours)

Dear [name], I've been thinking about you since I heard about [the news]. I'm so sorry. I have no idea whether you'd like company or peace at the moment, so please ignore this if it's the wrong time — but if a cup of tea or a walk would ever help, I would love to see you. There's no reply needed. With love, [your name]

i Script 3 — the phone call (if you would rather talk than write)

'Hello, is that [name]? It's [your name] — from [where you knew each other]. I know it's out of the blue. I've been meaning to ring for ages and today I just did. Have you got five minutes, or shall I ring another time?'

Then: one thing about you, one question about them, and stop after ten minutes unless they clearly want more. End with something concrete: 'Shall we do this again in a couple of weeks? I'll ring you.'

■ If there is no reply

- Wait two weeks. People are busy, unwell, away, or simply slow. Silence is rarely a verdict.
- Send one gentle follow-up if you want to ('Just checking this reached you — no worries if now isn't a good time'). Then leave it.
- Do not take one silence as evidence about all your friendships. Send three messages in Week 2 rather than one, so that no single reply carries the whole weight.
- Some friendships have run their course, and that is allowed. You reached out, which is the part you control. Move your attention to the next name.

The people you fell out with. Occasionally the lapsed friend is someone you argued with. If the thing was small and you are the one who could apologise, a short note that owns your part without relitigating the rest can be surprisingly powerful — 'I've thought about that summer more than once, and I'm sorry for my share of it. I'd like to be in touch again if you would.' If the thing was not small, or you were badly treated, you owe nobody a reconciliation. Leave them off the list and spend the energy elsewhere.

05 Part 5: Joining things

Joining is the fastest way to add scaffolding. A regular group gives you the same faces every week, a shared purpose that takes the pressure off conversation, and a ready-made reason to leave the house. The trick is choosing something you would go to even if nobody talked to you, so that the first three awkward visits are still worthwhile.

■ Where to find people, by what you like

Some of the organisations below are UK-only, some US-only, and a few exist in both. The right-hand columns give a starting point in each country; your local library, council or county website will know the rest.

If you like...	UK starting points	US starting points	Everywhere
Learning and talking	U3A groups (u3a.org.uk); WEA adult education classes; library talks; local history societies	Osher Lifelong Learning Institutes at 125 university campuses; community-college non-credit courses; library programmes	Book groups; language exchanges; lecture series at museums and galleries
Making and fixing	Men's Sheds (menssheds.org.uk — around 1,100 sheds, many welcoming women); Repair Cafés; craft groups at community centres	Men's Sheds (US Men's Sheds Association); makerspaces; community woodworking and craft classes	Allotments and community gardens; knitting and sewing circles; model-making clubs
Moving	parkrun (free, weekly, 5 km — walkers welcome and volunteers needed); Ramblers walking groups; bowls, swimming and tai chi at leisure centres	parkrun.us ; hiking clubs; senior centres and YMCA classes; pickleball (very sociable, very beginner-friendly)	Walking football; dance classes; cycling groups with a 'social pace' ride
Music and performance	Community choirs (no audition); folk sessions in pubs; ukulele groups; amateur dramatics	Community choruses; church and community bands; community theatre	Singing for wellbeing groups; open-mic nights; drumming circles
Being useful	Volunteering via your local Age UK, Royal Voluntary Service or Independent Age; Citizens Advice; food banks; National Trust; hospital volunteering	AARP volunteering pages; AmeriCorps Seniors; Habitat for Humanity; food banks; hospital and library volunteering	Charity shops (thrift stores); litter-picks; befriending schemes; school reading volunteers

If you like...	UK starting points	US starting points	Everywhere
Faith and reflection	Churches, chapels, mosques, synagogues, temples and gurdwaras almost all run weekday groups, lunches and coffee mornings	Congregations of every kind; many run seniors' fellowships and service projects	Meditation and mindfulness groups; retreat days; interfaith events
Games and puzzles	Bridge and chess clubs; quiz nights; board-game cafés; bowls	Bridge, mahjong and card groups at senior centres; trivia nights; board-game meetups	Online groups that meet in person once a month; crossword and puzzle clubs

■ A short glossary for readers on either side of the Atlantic

- **U3A (University of the Third Age)** — a UK network of local self-help learning groups for people no longer in full-time work. Members run the groups for each other; fees are modest. The nearest US equivalent is an Osher Lifelong Learning Institute (OLLI), which the Bernard Osher Foundation supports at 125 university and college campuses for learners aged 50 and over.
- **Men's Shed** — a community workshop-and-kettle where people, originally men, meet to make, mend and talk. The UK Men's Sheds Association counts around 1,100 sheds, and reports that between 30 and 40 per cent now have women members. There are Sheds in the US, Ireland, Australia and elsewhere.
- **parkrun** — free, weekly, timed 5 km (3.1 mile) events in parks on Saturday mornings, run by volunteers. People of every ability take part, walking is welcome, and volunteering (marshalling, timekeeping, tail-walking) is a social activity in its own right. It began in the UK and now runs in many countries, including the US at parkrun.us.
- **Community college** — in the US, local public colleges that run affordable non-credit courses for adults. The UK equivalents are adult education colleges and the WEA (Workers' Educational Association).
- **Allotment** — a UK term for a rented plot in a shared garden; a community garden in the US.
- **GP** — the UK term for a family doctor. **NHS** — the UK's health service.

■ The first three visits

- 1 **Before you go**, email or ring the organiser. 'I'm thinking of coming along on Thursday — is it all right to just turn up, and is there anything I should bring?' Now one person knows your name and is expecting you. That person will look out for you.
- 2 **Arrive five minutes early**, not late. Early arrivals get the organiser's attention; late arrivals slip into the back and talk to nobody.
- 3 **Have one sentence ready** for 'what brings you here?': 'I retired in the spring and I'm trying to get out of the house more.' Honest, short, and it invites the other person to say why they came.
- 4 **Ask a practical question** of whoever is nearest. 'Is it always this busy?' 'Where do people usually go for coffee afterwards?' Practical questions are easy to answer and often lead to an invitation.

- 5 Go three times before deciding.** Then decide honestly. If it is not for you, drop it without guilt and try the next thing on the table. Finding the right two groups usually takes four or five tries.

i If getting there, hearing or standing is the problem

Ask before you go. Most groups will tell you frankly whether the room has a hearing loop, step-free access, seating, and parking, and whether a member could give you a lift. Many U3A and OLLI groups run online sessions as well. If mobility or energy is limited, choose seated activities (bridge, choir, book group, craft) and telephone befriending as a starting point; Age UK's Telephone Friendship Service, run with The Silver Line, pairs people for a regular weekly call, and its Advice Line is 0800 678 1602.

06 Part 6: Hosting, simply

At some point you have to invite people in. It is the step most people put off longest, because they picture a dinner party: the cooking, the tidying, the seating plan, the worry. Forget the dinner party. The hosting that rebuilds circles is small, repeatable and slightly scruffy. The point is not the food; it is that you provided the reason to gather.

- **Tea and a walk.** 'Come at two, we'll walk round the reservoir and have a cup of tea back here.' No cooking, an activity to talk over, a natural end time.
- **Soup Tuesday.** One pan of soup, bread from the shop, a standing invitation to two or three people on the same day each month. Regularity beats grandeur.
- **The shared task.** Jam-making, bulb-planting, a jigsaw, sorting photographs, watching the match. People relax when their hands are busy.
- **Bring-a-plate.** Everyone brings one thing; you provide the table and the kettle. This is how most communities have always eaten together.
- **The quiet Sunday.** Invite one person for the afternoon with no programme at all. Papers, a pot of tea, a wander. For someone recently bereaved or newly retired this can be the kindest invitation of the month.

- 1 **Invite two or three, not eight.** Small groups talk; large groups perform. Two guests who do not know each other, plus you, is a very good number.
- 2 **Name the end time.** 'Two till four' is a gift to everyone, including you. People accept more readily when they know what they are agreeing to.
- 3 **Do not tidy beyond the room you will use.** Nobody is inspecting. A clean loo and a clear table are the whole standard.
- 4 **Have one thing to do and one thing to eat.** That is enough. A pot of tea, a plate of biscuits and a jigsaw has carried many a good afternoon.
- 5 **Invite again before they leave.** 'Same time next month?' Turn the one-off into a fixture. Fixtures are what your calendar is short of.
- 6 **If your home is not the place,** host elsewhere: 'my' table at the café on Wednesdays, a bench by the boating lake, the library meeting room, the pub's quiet corner at four. Hosting is providing the reason and the time, not the building.

07 Part 7: Family, near and far

■ Grandparenting as connection

If you have grandchildren, they are among the easiest and best connections available to you — but only if the relationship is yours rather than a by-product of babysitting. Regular, predictable, short, and centred on something the child likes to do with you is the recipe. A Wednesday teatime, a Saturday-morning swim, a monthly trip to the same museum. Children love routines with a grandparent even more than adults do, because the routine is the relationship.

- **Have a thing.** Baking, fishing, a card game, a bike ride, a particular series you watch together. The thing gives you both a reason and something to talk about between visits.
- **Ask the parents what would actually help,** and then do that, rather than what you would like to offer. The help that is wanted builds goodwill; the help that is not wanted builds friction.
- **Learn their world a little.** Ask a teenager to show you the game, the app, the music. Being taught by a grandchild is one of the closest connections there is, and it costs you nothing but a little pride.
- **Do not compete with the other grandparents,** or with the parents. Your job is to be a steady, unhurried adult who is delighted to see them. That is rarer and more valuable than it sounds.

■ Long-distance family

Family in another city or another country is where a screen genuinely earns its place. The AARP research is clear that technology is good at maintaining existing relationships, and family is exactly that. The failure mode is the vague 'we should call more'. The fix is a fixture.

- **Fix a slot.** Sunday at six, their time. Put it in both diaries. A fixed call that sometimes gets moved beats an intention that never happens.
- **Do something during the call,** not just talk. Read a chapter to a grandchild, cook the same recipe at the same time, watch a match or a quiz together, do a crossword down the line.
- **Send the small things.** A photograph of the garden, a postcard, a voice note about nothing in particular. Frequency of contact matters more than length.
- **Ask for help with something.** Being asked for advice on a phone setting, a recipe or a family memory tells a distant relative that they are needed, which is what everyone wants to be.
- **Visit with a purpose.** A visit organised around an event — a concert, a school play, a birthday, a walk you have always wanted to do — is easier for everyone to plan and to remember than an open-ended stay.

Adult children who have left. When children leave, parents often wait to be contacted, so as not to intrude. Adult children, meanwhile, are often waiting to be asked, so as not to seem needy. Everyone waits; nobody rings. Break the standoff by being the one who makes the small, regular, undemanding contact — a Sunday message, a photo, a 'no need to reply' — and by being plainly glad, rather than reproachful, when they do get in touch. The single most attractive quality in a parent of adult children is not needing them to feel guilty.

08 Part 8: Being a good friend, and saying no

■ When others need you

You will not be the only one in your circle going through something. As the years go on, more of your friends will be bereaved, ill, caring for someone, or simply frightened. How you show up for them is the deepest form of connection there is — and it is a skill, not a gift.

- **Turn up.** The friend in trouble does not need the perfect words. They need a person in the room. If you do not know what to say, say that: 'I don't know what to say, but I'm here.'
- **Offer something specific, not 'let me know if you need anything'.** 'I'm going to the shops on Thursday — give me your list.' 'I'll drive you to the hospital on Tuesday.' 'I'll sit with him on Saturday afternoon so you can get out.' Specific offers get accepted; open ones get politely declined.
- **Keep turning up after everyone else stops.** The casseroles stop at three weeks. The loneliness does not. The friend who is still ringing in month four is the one who is remembered.
- **Listen more than you advise.** Most people in difficulty know what they have to do. They want to be heard doing it. Questions ('what's the hardest bit at the moment?') are worth more than solutions.
- **Let them help you too.** Being needed is a comfort. Ask the bereaved friend's advice, borrow their tools, let them cook for you. A friendship where the help goes one way only becomes a duty.

■ Saying no

A fuller social life needs a working 'no'. Without it you will end up doing things you dislike with people who drain you, and then quietly withdrawing from everything to recover. Saying no well is what makes saying yes sustainable. It is also a sign of respect: it tells people your yes means something.

- **Decline the thing, not the person.** 'Thursday evenings aren't good for me, but I'd love to do a walk one afternoon.' You are saying no to the format and yes to the friendship.
- **Do not give a long reason.** 'I can't manage that, I'm afraid' is a complete sentence. Explanations invite negotiation.
- **Protect the fixtures.** The Wednesday class, the Sunday call, the Tuesday soup: these are the scaffolding, and you defend them as you would a medical appointment.
- **Say no to the committee, yes to the group.** Newcomers who are helpful get asked to run things. It is flattering, and it can swallow the pleasure of the thing. 'Ask me again next year' is a fair answer.
- **Notice who drains you** and see them less, without drama. You do not owe anyone a share of your week. Spend it on the people who leave you feeling better.



If you are the carer

Caring for someone squeezes social life harder than almost anything else. Two things help. First, connection that happens inside the caring: the carers' group at the hospital or the library, the online forum, the other spouse in the day-centre car park. Second, protecting one fixture a week that is only yours, and asking directly for the cover to make it happen. In the UK, Carers UK and your local carers' centre can advise on respite; in the US, the Family Caregiver Alliance and your Area Agency on Aging are the equivalent starting points.

09 Part 9: The six-week plan

Each week has a theme and seven small tasks. Most take twenty minutes; the weekend ones may take an afternoon. Tick the box in the right-hand column and add a word or two on how it felt — that column becomes the most useful thing in the guide. Move tasks between days as you need to; the order within a week is flexible, but try to finish each week before starting the next. If you are living with grief or illness, do half of each day's task and call that the plan.

■ Week 1 — Audit and foundations

Mon	Begin the seven-day contact log from Part 2. Write today's line before bed. Decide on your two 'regular' places (a café, a walk, a service, a swim) and write them at the top of the log.	☐
Tue	Go to one of your regular places at the time you will use every week. Say one more sentence than usual to somebody there.	☐
Wed	Fill in the three circles table. Be honest about the middle circle. Write the names of three lapsed friends you would like to hear from.	☐
Thu	Search for two groups from the 'where to find people' table that you would enjoy even if nobody spoke to you. Write down when and where they meet.	☐
Fri	Ring or message one person in your inner circle just to talk — no purpose, ten minutes. Notice how it feels to be the one who rang.	☐
Sat	Go to your second regular place. Learn one name. Write it down when you get home.	☐
Sun	Finish the log. Answer the five audit questions in writing. Fill in the Week 1 row of the progress log at the back.	☐

■ Week 2 — Reaching back

Mon	Send Script 1 (adapted) to the first lapsed friend on your list. Short, warm, expectation-free. Then put the phone down and do something else.	☐
Tue	Regular place, same time. Use the name you learned last week. Ask one question about their week.	☐
Wed	Send a message to the second lapsed friend. Different person, different reason for writing. Two messages out means no single reply carries everything.	☐
Thu	Email or ring the organiser of one of the two groups you found. Ask whether you can come along next week and whether to bring anything.	☐
Fri	Ring the third lapsed friend, using Script 3, or write if you would rather. Ten minutes, then a concrete 'shall we speak again in a fortnight?'	☐
Sat	Second regular place. Offer one small piece of help to somebody — hold the door, pass something on, save a seat.	☐
Sun	Fixed family call, if you have family away. Agree a slot for next week too. Fill in the progress log.	☐

■ Week 3 — Joining

Mon	Plan your first group visit: how you will get there, what you will wear, your one-sentence answer to 'what brings you here?'. Reply to any messages that came back from Week 2.	☐ _____
Tue	Regular place. If a chat is starting to happen, let it run a minute longer than usual.	☐ _____
Wed	First visit to the new group. Arrive five minutes early. Ask one practical question. Stay for the coffee afterwards if there is one.	☐ _____
Thu	Write down two names from the group and one thing you learned about each person. Follow up one Week 2 message if it has been silent for ten days — once only.	☐ _____
Fri	Look up one volunteering option near you (Age UK, Royal Voluntary Service, a food bank, parkrun volunteering, a library). Just look; no commitment yet.	☐ _____
Sat	Regular place, or try a parkrun as a walker or volunteer. Say hello to the person next to you at the start.	☐ _____
Sun	Family call. Progress log. Write one sentence about how the group visit felt, and decide to go twice more before judging.	☐ _____

■ Week 4 — Hosting and deepening

Mon	Invite two people — one from your middle circle and one newer acquaintance if you dare — to something simple next weekend: tea and a walk, soup, a jigsaw afternoon. Name the start and end time.	☐ _____
Tue	Regular place. Ask the person you talk to most whether they ever go for coffee afterwards, or whether they would like to.	☐ _____
Wed	Second visit to the group. Sit somewhere different. Talk to someone you did not talk to last time.	☐ _____
Thu	Shop for the hosting day. Keep it to one thing to eat and one thing to do. Clean the loo and clear the table; do nothing else.	☐ _____
Fri	Ring a friend who is going through something hard. Offer one specific thing rather than 'let me know if you need anything'.	☐ _____
Sat	Host. Small, short, scruffy. Before they leave, suggest the same again next month.	☐ _____
Sun	Family call. Progress log. Note who you enjoyed most yesterday and why.	☐ _____

■ Week 5 — Giving

Mon	Sign up for the volunteering option you looked at in Week 3, or book a first shift or induction. If none suited, choose one from the 'being useful' row of the table.	☐ _____
Tue	Regular place. If a coffee afterwards is now on offer, go.	☐ _____
Wed	Third visit to the group. Now judge it honestly: stay, or thank them and try the other group on your list next week.	☐ _____
Thu	Do one thing for a neighbour or an outer-circle person: bring the bin in, pass on a plant cutting, drop a note through the door of someone you have not seen for a while.	☐ _____
Fri	Practise one 'no'. Decline something you do not want to do, warmly and briefly, and offer an alternative you do want.	☐ _____
Sat	Volunteering shift, parkrun volunteering, or a second regular place. Learn the name of one person you work alongside.	☐ _____
Sun	Family call. If you have grandchildren, propose a regular 'thing' — a fortnightly swim, a monthly museum, a Wednesday tea. Progress log.	☐ _____

■ Week 6 — Fixtures and what next

Mon	Look at the whole progress log. List every contact that could become a fixture: the coffee after the class, the monthly soup, the Sunday call, the volunteering shift.	☐ _____
Tue	Regular place. Tell someone there what you have been doing for the last six weeks. Saying it aloud makes it real, and they may want to join in.	☐ _____
Wed	Group, or the alternative group if you switched. Ask whether anyone would like to meet up outside the session — a walk, a talk, a pub lunch.	☐ _____
Thu	Write to the lapsed friends who replied and propose something concrete: a date, a place, a time. Turn the reconnection into a plan.	☐ _____
Fri	Put every fixture into your diary for the next three months. Weekly, fortnightly or monthly — but written down.	☐ _____
Sat	Do the thing you enjoyed most in the six weeks, again. Take someone with you if you can.	☐ _____
Sun	Repeat the seven-day contact log this week and compare it with Week 1. Fill in the final row of the progress log and write one kind sentence to yourself.	☐ _____

10 Progress log

Fill in one row each Sunday. Numbers are not the point, but they are encouraging: most people find the first column doubles between Week 1 and Week 6, and that the last column is where the real change shows.

Week	People I talked with (different people)	In-person contacts	New names learned	Messages or calls I started	Fixtures now in the diary	The best moment
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						

- ☐ I kept the seven-day contact log in Week 1 and again in Week 6
- ☐ I have two regular places I go to at the same time each week
- ☐ I contacted three lapsed friends, and followed up once where needed
- ☐ I visited a new group three times before deciding about it
- ☐ I hosted something small, and suggested doing it again
- ☐ I did one thing for someone who needed it, and offered something specific
- ☐ I said one warm, brief 'no'
- ☐ I have a fixed slot for family who live away
- ☐ I have at least three fixtures written in the diary for the next three months
- ☐ I wrote one kind sentence to myself at the end

11 Troubleshooting

"I'm shy, and this all sounds exhausting" Then do less of it, more regularly. Shyness is not a barrier to connection; it is a preference for smaller doses. Choose one regular place rather than two, one group rather than two, and hosting one person rather than three. Weak ties suit shy people particularly well, because they ask nothing more than being present and pleasant. And the one-sentence rule — say one more sentence than usual, not ten — is designed for exactly you.

"Everyone at the group already knows each other" They did not, once. Every one of them was new, and most of them remember it. Established groups can look closed from the doorway and turn out to be welcoming at the coffee table. Give it the three visits. If after three it is genuinely cliquish — nobody speaks to you, nobody asks your name — that is a poor group, not a poor you. Try the other one on your list. Groups vary enormously, and the difference is usually one or two warm people who set the tone.

"Nobody replied" One silence is noise. Three silences might be a signal — but look at what you sent. Was it short? Did it give a reason for writing? Did it ask a light question and make clear no long reply was needed? Long, apologetic or heavy messages are hard to answer and often left for 'later', which never comes. Try again with a two-line version to a different person. And remember that the messages you send are the part you control; the replies are not, and they say more about the other person's week than about you.

"I can't get out much" Then bring connection in. Telephone befriending, regular fixed calls with family and friends, online U3A or OLLI sessions, a book group that meets on video, a neighbour invited in for tea every Tuesday. Ask groups whether a member could give you a lift; many will. And make the most of the people who come to you — the carer, the cleaner, the delivery driver, the district nurse — with names, questions and thanks. Weak ties do not care whether you can drive.

"It's my partner who does the social side" This is very common, particularly among men, and it leaves people badly exposed if the partner dies or becomes ill. AARP's 2025 research found men over 45 in the US now report loneliness at higher rates than women. The answer is to have at least one thing that is yours: a group, a shift, a regular walk with a friend, where you go without your partner and where people know you in your own right. Start it now, while it is easy, rather than later, when it will be needed.

"I feel low most of the time, and this isn't touching it" Then please talk to your GP (family doctor). Loneliness and low mood feed each other, and sometimes the mood has to be looked after before the connection can grow. There is nothing weak about asking. In the UK, Age UK's Advice Line (0800 678 1602, 8am to 7pm every day) can also point you to local support, and The Silver Line helpline is there at any time of day or night. In the US, the AARP website lists local resources, and your doctor or Area Agency on Aging can do the same. This guide will still be here when you are ready for it.

12 Finishing, and what next

If you have reached this page after six weeks, look back at the two contact logs. However the numbers compare, you have done the things that were actually in doubt: you reached out first, you turned up three times, you invited people in, you were useful to someone, and you said no once. Most people never do all five in a year. You did them in six weeks.

- **Guard the fixtures.** They are the scaffolding. When one falls away — a group closes, a friend moves — replace it within a month rather than letting the gap widen.
- **Run the plan again in six months.** Different lapsed friends, a different group, a different way of being useful. The method does not wear out.
- **Keep the log habit, lightly.** One line a week — 'who did I see?' — is enough to notice a shrinking circle early, when it is easy to fix.
- **Become the welcomer.** In a year you will be the established member at the group. Be the one who notices the new person at the door. It is the most useful thing you can do for them, and one of the most connecting things you can do for yourself.

Reconnect is one part of what we do at dontdieretired.com. If it has been useful, two things will help you keep the momentum:

- **The newsletter** — a short, useful email each week with one idea, one thing to try and one piece of honest evidence. No hype. Sign up at dontdieretired.com/newsletter.
- **The members' circle** — a small, friendly group of readers who keep each other company on the way, swap ideas for groups and outings, and are glad to see a new name. Details at dontdieretired.com/circle.



One last thing

You did not lose the ability to make friends. You lost the places where it used to happen by accident.
You now know how to build those places on purpose. Keep going.

Sources

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Every figure in this guide comes from one of the pages above, which we read before writing; where a number could not be verified, we left it out. **Reconnect** is a publication of dontdieretired.com. This guide offers general information about social wellbeing and is not medical advice. If low mood persists, or is getting in the way of everyday life, speak to your GP.

KEEP GOING

This is the start, not the finish.

Every day at dontdieretired.com we publish a true story of someone who began something late — and the plan behind it. Join the free Sunday email and you'll get one story, one idea and one thing to try each week.

MORE FROM THE SHELF

The 30-Day Restart

Ten minutes a day, chair to stairs

Strong at 60

12-week beginner strength plan

Eat Strong

Four-week kitchen planner

Sharp

8 weeks to a learning habit

The Money Reset

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